



BACK FROM THE BRINK

Vasundhara Raje's peace deal buys temporary respite from a caste conflict but the issue can still return to haunt her

■ By Rohit Parihar

Rajasthan Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje is a firm believer in destiny and divine intervention. The developments over the past two weeks have only firmed up her belief. Last Tuesday, 24 hours after she had reached a breakthrough agreement with Gurjar leaders and saved the state from anarchy, she turned to her grandson Vinayak Dushyant Singh and daughter-in-law Niharika and said: "Let us go to the temple." She then remarked to a waiting mediaperson: "When I seek His blessings in trouble, I must not forget Him after it is over." Her thanksgiving may have been for emerging as a remarkable negotiator, but more than anything, it underlined her qualities as a survivor. Nobody can say if the peace deal is durable but she has certainly gained a well-earned reprieve, from the Gurjar agitation as well as in her political role, with rivals in the BJP baying for her blood. They now realise that she is a formidable opponent. Her strategy may have sent the wrong signals initially when violence was getting out of control and she was conspicuous by her absence. Only later did it turn out that she was holding hectic consultations with Delhi and within her state party, including advisers like Niharika, herself a high-born Gurjar. She also reasoned that anything she said to the media could be misconstrued, hence her silence.

Where she was let down was by the local administration and the police. Before the agitation began, she was away in Delhi but her brief to them was not to let the Gurjars disrupt communications on the national highway.

However, once the police resorted to firing, the Government was at the receiving end not only from Gurjar leaders but also from within the BJP. Senior leaders like Jaswant Singh were quoted as saying that "*raj dharma*" was not adhered to. That forced her to rethink strategy. It was clear that millions of Gurjars would react with greater violence to the killing of six members of their community, so her decision was to allow them to let off steam and block highways, even at the cost of damage to public property. She also called in the army and Rapid Action Force, but merely for presence, not an active role.

It worked. Tempers cooled and by the fifth day, with the agitation largely under control, she began the hard part of negotiations. She realised that the Gurjar leaders, after losing 20 lives in

Faced with the biggest crisis of her chief ministership, Raje emerged as survivor and canny political strategist, trumping her opponents... for now.

the agitation, would need something concrete to take back to their people. Raje, knowing her government was under tremendous pressure, played her trump card: the threat by the powerful Meenas who had not only opposed entry of Gurjars into Scheduled Tribe (ST) reservation but said they would clear road blockades if the Government failed to do so. While reassuring both sides, Raje made it clear to the Gurjars that



they would have to face serious repercussions from the Meenas if they continued the agitation. With most males in Gurjar families out on the streets, their women and children at home were extremely vulnerable.

To their credit, the Gurjar leadership under Colonel Kirori Singh Bainsla was uncomfortable with the manner in which groups of hooligans had come out looking for violence. It was a seri-